



Deep red Santa Gertrudis cattle roaming the Urbanosky Ranch in January 2026.

Photograph by Jeff Wilson

NEWS & POLITICS

One Man's Quest for the End of the World Started on a Ranch in Texas

A Texas businessman believes he was divinely chosen to help usher in the Second Coming of Christ—by finding unblemished red heifers and getting them to Israel.

By Andrew Logan

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It was nearly Christmas, and Jerome Urbanosky was expecting unusual company. The easygoing 72-year-old rancher stood outside his redbrick home, watching as a dozen or so vehicles crunched along the gravel road that winds through the grassy plain of his 1,500-acre ranch

northwest of Houston. The delegation that piled out into his driveway included high-ranking rabbis who'd flown straight from Israel, a U.S. documentary crew toting multiple cameras, and a Texas businessman named Byron Stinson.

Urbanosky was taken aback by the size of the crew—but that wasn't the thing that startled him the most. Four men dressed in black tactical gear and carrying military rifles approached and told him they needed to sweep the property to make sure no "foreign agents" were present. "They were armed to the teeth," Urbanosky remembered. He wasn't inclined to stand in their way. His wife, Jane, who was in the kitchen preparing the weekly Sunday meal, stared saucer-eyed as the armed men entered her home.

Once the security team cleared the property, Urbanosky led the rabbis to a red barn, where two calves awaited. Urbanosky Ranch is home to a herd of more than 450 Santa Gertrudis cattle, a hardy breed that's known to produce good beef and whose origins trace back to the King Ranch, in South Texas. But as Urbanosky knew, this delegation wasn't here for a steak.

Santa Gertrudis cattle also have striking coats of deep rusty red, which is what had initially attracted Stinson's attention. A seventy-year-old Glen Rose business owner who's described himself as a "Jesus zealot," Stinson had visited Urbanosky at his ranch once before and explained that he was in search of an unblemished, completely red heifer—a scratch or a single white hair, and it wouldn't do. Such a heifer hadn't been identified in two thousand years, but it was key to unlocking an ancient Jewish ritual described in the book of Numbers, a necessary precursor to constructing the Third Temple in Jerusalem and, ultimately, bringing about the Second Coming of Christ. It's a fringe but nonetheless influential belief, and Stinson's Israeli associate, Yitshak Mamo, had convinced Urbanosky that he, too, was essential to this journey.

Urbanosky, a Catholic who attends weekly Mass, had never heard of the Jewish ceremony. He was wary at first, but Stinson was tireless, and Mamo told Urbanosky that, just maybe, God had indeed chosen him to deliver the

sacred heifer. “It has shaken my psyche,” he said. “I don’t have this superiority complex. I know that my wife doesn’t think I’m anything special.”

Fantastical as Stinson’s end-time scheme may sound, its real-world consequences are grave—and have the potential to become far more explosive. The pursuit has already heightened tensions in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and was cited by Hamas as one reason for the October 7, 2023, attack on Israel. Stinson’s efforts have sparked headlines across the Middle East, been criticized by international Christian leaders, and made him an unlikely but consequential figure in one of the most delicate and contentious religiopolitical issues in the world.

In Texas, Stinson has largely flown under the radar, but he’s left an impression on those who’ve encountered him. As Ty Davenport, another rancher who got swept up in Stinson’s quest, told me: “There is something going on here, way more than just meets the eye.”

Byron Stinson looking out from his land in Glen Rose in January 2026.
Photograph by Jeff Wilson

When I first met Byron Stinson, in Glen Rose in May 2024, he greeted me outside his transportation-logistics company's office, exuding a warm, good ol' boy charm. As he escorted me inside the limestone-and-glass building, I noticed the Hebrew lettering on his T-shirt. Stinson, his grinning face framed by blunt bangs and a mustache-

less white beard, explained that it was the logo for Goldstar beer, the “Shiner Bock of Israel.”

We stepped into the lobby, where a kitschy choose-your-own-adventure-style mural stretches across two wide walls. The left panel depicts the story of a devout Christian. In the man’s office, a Bible rests on his desk, and a painting of Jesus tending to a flock of sheep hangs behind him. The mural follows the subject’s life as he guides others to Christ and ultimately receives his heavenly reward, symbolized by a semitruck driving into a sunset. The panel on the right shows an alternate version of the same man rejecting the son of God and falling into despair. In this rendering, his religious office decor is replaced with a calendar of a woman in a black minidress posing on the hood of a yellow sports car. The story culminates at a truck stop, where the despondent man sits in his red semi while someone solicits prostitution from two women in the background. Stinson chuckled as he told me that the illustrated faces, though not the stories, are depictions of his actual employees.

We sat together at a table in his office, and Stinson told me the story of how he became obsessed with the red heifer. He grew up in a loving, working-class family in Glen Rose. Both of his parents were truck drivers, and they often left Byron alone for weeks on end. By the time he was a teenager, Byron, already consumed by his faith, had accepted Jesus as his savior once, been baptized twice, and read the Bible three times. One evening in 1969, when Byron was fourteen, he sat on his bed inside a muggy six-by-nine-foot storage shed outside the camper trailer where he lived with his mother and adoptive father. As he pored over the book of Romans in his worn copy of the King James Bible, the words of Paul the Apostle seemed to leap off the page: “For I could wish that myself were accursed from Christ for my brethren, my kinsmen according to the flesh: Who are Israelites.” Paul wrote that he would surrender his own salvation if it meant the Israelites would accept Jesus; Byron felt overwhelmed with an urge to follow Paul’s example. Then Stinson heard voices.

To his left, a voice declared, “I’m going to use him to help the Jewish people.” It was, Byron knew instantly, the voice of God. But then another voice—this one possessing a calm, unemotional contempt—responded from his right. “He will be a failure,” it said. “He is full of lust and all kinds of horrible sins. He won’t be able to do anything for you.” The response came from Lucifer, he realized. He believed he was overhearing celestial forces bickering over his destiny. “The next morning, I did not tell my mother, I did not tell my friends, I did not tell anybody,” Stinson recounted. “I didn’t want to be thought of as crazy.”

But the experience stayed with him, even as he drifted from his faith. He aspired to become a musician—his late cousin **Paul English** was a longtime drummer for Willie Nelson—and at eighteen, Stinson left Glen Rose and spent five years traveling all over the U.S. and Mexico, picking up gigs playing drums with various bands. At one point he and a girlfriend lived in Acapulco with several friends who were sex workers. The couple sometimes looked after their housemates’ kids. “I sowed my wild oats about as big as anybody could,” Stinson said. “I was an idiot.”

He eventually returned to Glen Rose, where he founded his company. In his thirties, Stinson felt called back to his faith, and when an old buddy told him that his church’s praise and worship band needed a drummer, he jumped at the opportunity. He thrived in church, and in his early forties he decided to settle down and start a family with a woman he’d met at work and who had become his best friend. He and Tammy eventually raised eight children, including two each from their previous marriages.

In 1999 the church was invited to participate in a revival in Ireland, where Stinson’s band performed before a crowd of around three hundred pastors. Recalling the event, he told me that the “Holy Spirit fell like fire.” There he met with Mark Rutland, who would become the president of Oral Roberts University, the influential private evangelical college based in Oklahoma. Rutland invited Stinson on a trip to Israel, and a year later, in 2000, Stinson traveled to the Holy Land for the first time.

His visit coincided with the early stages of the second intifada, a violent conflict between Israelis and Palestinians following a visit made by soon-to-be prime minister Ariel Sharon to the Temple Mount, one of the holiest and most contested sites in Jerusalem. It's believed to be where the First and Second Temples once stood and is home to the Al-Aqsa Mosque, one of Islam's most sacred shrines. During Stinson's stay, two Israeli soldiers were lynched in the Palestinian city of Ramallah, sparking international outrage. When Stinson returned home, he was shocked to learn that none of his friends had heard about it. The killings were widely covered in the U.S., including on the front page of *The New York Times*, but Stinson claimed that they had been hidden from Americans by politicians and media outlets who were misleading the public about what was happening in the region.

Using money from leasing the rights to drill for gas on farmland he'd purchased just outside of Glen Rose, Stinson helped fund multiple projects that he believed proved the authenticity of the Bible, such as restoring the Garden of Gethsemane, the location on the Mount of Olives where Jesus prayed and was arrested before his crucifixion, and helping conserve biblical artifacts that are now on display at a private museum in the Flint Hills of Kansas. Over the next two decades, Stinson visited Israel multiple times a year, so often that he decided to purchase a second home in Jerusalem, where he now spends three or four months of the year.



One panel of the mural at Stinson's Glen Rose business office depicting Jesus carrying the cross.
Photograph by Jeff Wilson



Stinson holding a book he wrote about his hunt for the red heifer.

Photograph by Jeff Wilson

Through his work there, he befriended Yitshak Mamo, a controversial figure in the region for his efforts to evict Palestinian families from their homes in East Jerusalem and assert Jewish ownership over those properties.

According to Aviv Tatarsky, a researcher at Ir Amim, an Israeli nonprofit that promotes a two-state solution, Mamo's efforts play well among those in favor of the expansion of Jewish settlements, which is among the most divisive issues in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Many Palestinians view Jewish settlements in occupied territories as a broad strategy to permanently displace them. "If you are supporting the settlements, you really, really like him," Tatarsky said. "And if you are opposing them, then he's the bad guy, the evil demon."

Mamo rarely speaks with the press, and he declined multiple interview requests for this story. ("What you have seen me say, I stand behind. What others say in my name or understand from me or hear from me, please treat accordingly," he wrote to me.)

Mamo also leads Uvne Jerusalem, an organization that belongs to the Temple Mount movement, a small coalition of extremist orthodox Jewish and nationalist groups whose objective is to build the Third Temple of Jerusalem. (The First Temple was destroyed circa 587 BC, the Second in AD 70.) The proposed construction site, on the Temple Mount, would be an explosive provocation in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, which is one reason only about 10 percent of Israeli Jews support efforts to rebuild the temple, according to a 2023 survey conducted by Motti Inbari, a professor of philosophy and religion at the University of North Carolina at Pembroke. (The traditional Jewish view is that a physical temple already exists in heaven and will be brought down by God.) Still, the influence of Temple Mount activists like Mamo is growing, and Stinson joined their coalition. He and Mamo eventually partnered to start a Texas-based nonprofit called Boneh Israel, which translates to "Building Israel."

In the summer of 2021, Stinson got a phone call from Mamo. Mamo asked him to do something no one else had been able to do for thousands of years: Locate an unblemished red heifer and get her to Israel.

By then, Stinson knew all about the importance of red heifers. According to scripture, they were essential for an ancient purification ritual: Jews who wished to enter the Temple must first be sprinkled with the ashes of an unblemished red heifer mixed with natural spring water. Mamo was asking Stinson to get him a step closer to rebuilding the Temple.

The last recorded red-heifer ceremony took place two thousand years ago, before the destruction of the Second Temple, during the Roman siege of Jerusalem. Because of the growing influence of Temple Mount activists, there have been renewed attempts to locate or produce unblemished red heifers in the past three decades, but none have been successful.

Stinson saw Mamo's request as an opportunity to fulfill the divine calling he'd heard at fourteen. But he would do more than deliver just one, he pledged. Stinson draws significant meaning from numbers, and for this assignment, he fixated on the number of days it took God to create the world, including the holy day of rest. He immediately prayed, "Lord, give me seven."

Stinson is not a rancher, but he has family roots in the business: His great-grandfather, oilman W. J. McAlister, bought the Goodnight Ranch from legendary Texas cattle rancher Charles Goodnight in 1919. That land didn't stay in his family, but Stinson now owns an eighty-acre pecan and coastal hay farm where he lets a friend raise around thirty head of cattle, and he's well connected in the industry. After accepting Mamo's mission, Stinson called his cowboy friends to learn what breeds of cattle are red and won't lose their color as they age. With their expertise, he identified two promising types: Santa Gertrudis and Red Angus.

Jerome Urbanosky on his ranch near Houston, where Stinson and Yitshak Mamo discovered unblemished heifers.

Photograph by Jeff Wilson

Stinson enlisted the help of his 37-year-old adopted son, Cody Holmes, a business-intelligence developer who used a Python script to scrape the websites of ranchers associations and compiled a list of around eight hundred ranchers throughout the United States that raised red cattle. Stinson sent them text messages and mailed flyers offering top-market price for qualified heifers, plus an additional \$15,000 for any selected for a ceremony.

Messages from ranchers as far away as Montana, Missouri, and Alabama started to trickle in. But Stinson would inevitably spot disqualifying traits—a few white hairs, tagged ears, a rancher’s brand—in the photos they’d send. He did get promising leads in Texas, though. Over the next three months, Stinson and his Boneh Israel team visited around twenty ranches, from Texarkana to Abilene, and inspected dozens of cows, none of which met the qualifications.

Finally, Stinson's search led him to Urbanosky Ranch. Urbanosky, who also runs a staffing agency, said he received a cold call from Stinson in late summer of 2021. Stinson explained what he was looking for and made clear his ultimate goal: rebuilding the Temple in Jerusalem. "It kind of catches me off guard," said Urbanosky, who had recently served as the president of Santa Gertrudis Breeders International. "This isn't a typical kind of call that you get. I mean, it's just pretty bizarre." Urbanosky's wife, Jane, was skeptical. The story was so ridiculous, she warned, it must be a scam.

Initially, Urbanosky told Stinson that the prospects were slim. Despite their silky red appearance, Santa Gertrudis usually have at least some white hairs. Plus, all of Urbanosky's cattle were ear tagged. But Stinson insisted that Urbanosky look around anyway. So Urbanosky drove a mile and a half down the road to his son Blake's small ranch, which raises show cows. He discovered three heifers still nursing out in the pasture. They hadn't been tagged yet. Urbanosky rounded them up and called Stinson.

Stinson told Urbanosky that two associates were flying in from Israel to help him inspect the heifers. A week later, a shiny blue Chevrolet pickup truck pulled into the ranch. Out stepped Stinson, along with Mamo and four others from Boneh Israel. Urbanosky shook hands, made introductions, and had begun to lead them to the barn when Mamo stopped him. "Before we go out there, I want to know your story," Urbanosky remembers Mamo telling him.

"Well, I don't really have a story," Urbanosky replied. "I'm just a guy that has some cows."

"No, I want to hear your story," Mamo insisted. "I want to know everything about you."

Urbanosky told Mamo the unlikely tale of how he came to operate one of the largest Santa Gertrudis ranches in the country despite not growing up in a powerful Texas ranching family. When Urbanosky was fifteen years old, he won the **Houston Livestock Show and Rodeo**'s calf scramble, earning \$200 for catching the first calf. With his winnings and the help of his dad and his high school agricultural-science teacher, he purchased his first heifer for

\$350. He named her Alice. “I spent every bit of time I could with her,” Urbanosky said. “I loved her and she loved me.”

After winning several small livestock shows, Urbanosky entered Alice in the 1970 Houston Livestock Show, the largest such event in the world. Not only did Alice win the Santa Gertrudis Junior Show and the Scramble Division, but she also made history when she became the first Santa Gertrudis at the show to win Grand Champion Scramble Heifer. The three large trophies and bragging rights he took home were worth more to Urbanosky than money. His success ignited his passion for ranching, and he was able to breed Alice and sell her calves, laying the foundation for his herd today.

Mamo stepped slowly toward Urbanosky and pointed his index finger, nearly touching Urbanosky’s nose. “You’re part of the story,” Mamo said. “God selected you two thousand years ago, that you would be the one to deliver the red heifer.”

Urbanosky, unsure what to make of this, showed the entourage into the red sheet metal barn where the young heifers awaited. He ushered the cows through a squeeze chute so that Mamo could inspect them. All the while, Mamo was on a video call with a group of rabbis in Israel, including officials from the Temple Institute, one of the most powerful Temple Mount movement organizations. During the inspection, Urbanosky made small talk with Stinson. Urbanosky told me he knew “doodley-squat” about the significance of a perfect red heifer. “You’re Christian, and they’re Jews,” Urbanosky said to Stinson. “So when the Temple gets built, who’s coming back, Jesus or the Jewish messiah?”

Stinson chuckled, acknowledging the differing views represented by his entourage. “Well, that’s what we’re going to find out,” he said.

Typical buyers would’ve taken fifteen to thirty minutes to inspect the three heifers, Urbanosky said. Mamo spent two hours on the first one alone, examining every inch of the animal’s body. Once finished, Mamo stood up. “This is one of the greatest days of my life,” he said. “I told you that I was going to find her here.”

Everybody stood momentarily speechless, then they quickly moved to inspect the others. After another hours-long inspection, a second passed. Mamo asked if Urbanosky could hold the qualified calves until he could return with a larger group to do a final inspection. The rancher agreed.

The red heifers from Texas feeding in their pen in the West Bank.
Photograph by Maya Levin

Despite what Mamo considered to be a miraculous discovery, Stinson remained determined to locate all seven heifers that he'd promised. His search led him to the tiny town of McLendon-Chisholm, just east of Dallas, in early October 2021. Triple Creek Ranch is owned by Ty Davenport, a 77-year-old retired veterinarian whose white hair, mustache, and swagger evoke a Sam Elliott character. After he asked God to baptize him in 1991, Davenport "became infatuated with Daddy's word," he told me with a breathy rasp, adding that he spends two to three hours a day reading the Bible. He now serves as a part-time lay pastor, occasionally preaching at the nondenominational JOY Church in Sunnyvale, about twenty miles from the ranch. He was familiar with the passage in Numbers that references the red heifer, but Davenport hadn't heard of the effort to

locate one for a modern-day ceremony until Stinson showed up. “I wasn’t prepared for what was getting ready to happen,” said Davenport.

With an upbeat stride, Davenport led Stinson and Mamo to his four-seat all-terrain vehicle. The seasoned rancher drove through his 1,200-acre spread, scouring the property for newborn calves, because his other three hundred Red Angus cattle had been ear tagged. After several hours, the men grew disheartened. They took a break and, under the shade of a hackberry tree, bowed their heads to pray. They then drove back out to the pasture and spotted a cow emerging from the woods with a newborn calf. The mother’s ear was tagged with the number eight, which they considered a divine sign. (In biblical numerology, eight is associated with new beginnings. There were eight survivors, for example, on Noah’s ark.) Mamo inspected the heifer and, through tears, confirmed to the others that it was perfect. “You start seeing another man cry, you know, it gets your attention,” Davenport said.

Stinson returned to Triple Creek again in December with the same entourage that had visited Urbanosky Ranch. The calving season had just ended, and they arrived to find dozens of new prospects. Given the amount of time it takes to examine each animal, the rabbis were able to fully inspect and approve only eight of them. Stinson decided to stick around longer, and with the help of a ranch hand who’d been assisting with inspections, he identified an additional eleven heifers. Along with the two cows from Urbanosky, Stinson now had a total of 21 unblemished red heifers—three times the number he’d promised Mamo.

Davenport, having come to believe in Stinson’s divine mission, donated some of his heifers to Boneh Israel, which in turn connected them to Mamo’s group, Uvne Jerusalem. “I’m a simple cowboy,” Davenport said. “I’m really excited to be part of these end times.”

S tinson, who made his fortune in transportation logistics, figured the hard part was done, that getting a few animals overseas would be simple. Sure, he’d have to minimize risk to the heifers—even suffering a small cut that healed into a scar could disqualify them from the ritual—but that was only the beginning of his troubles. It turns out that

shipping 21 red heifers to Israel would be even more difficult than finding them.

He began by making arrangements to fly the cows directly from Houston's George Bush Intercontinental Airport to the Israeli city of Tel Aviv, about a fifteen-hour direct flight. That's when he hit his first obstacle: Airlines restrict the amount of time animals can spend on a plane without a "comfort break." He also learned that Israel doesn't permit the importing of live cattle from the United States. He'd have to devise a work-around.

Stinson enlisted the services of Frank de Leede, a Dutch equestrian-transportation specialist, who suggested routing the cows through Belgium, a common stopover he uses when moving high-dollar thoroughbreds. If the cows were kept on the ground for 24 hours, Stinson presumed that'd solve the other problem—the animals could then be considered European. He'd simply apply for an Israeli import license listing the heifers' origin as Belgium. But that plan was stymied when Belgian officials told Stinson they wouldn't let the cows off the plane except for a wellness check, which had to be completed in less than twelve hours. Stinson described the ordeal as "too many bureaucrats that didn't like each other."

He was briefly deflated but soon began exploring other options. London seemed promising until an official in the UK government raised concerns about mad cow disease. He turned to the Netherlands, but officials there offered a bizarre excuse, citing a massive shipment of frozen salmon that was headed to Israel for Passover. Apparently it would have made the plane too cold for the animals. When Stinson attempted to book them on a later flight, he said he kept running into conflicting requirements from Dutch and Israeli officials. "That was just a big fiasco," he said.

Stinson tried to get creative. He briefly flirted with exporting the heifers as zoo animals, and even contacted a crocodile farm near the Sea of Galilee for advice, but yet again his efforts went nowhere. A couple of weeks passed, and Stinson was nearing his breaking point. Then he remembered something: the simple form he'd filled out several times to bring his dog with him on trips to Jerusalem. He pulled up the requirements on his computer and

learned that it's legal to import up to 5 pets from the United States to Israel. He'd have to reduce the number from 21 to 5, but nonetheless his prayers had been answered.

The heifers required some sort of identification, so, after Mamo consulted with the Temple Institute, Davenport implanted ID chips “the size of a grain of rice” behind their ears using a hypodermic needle that wouldn't cause scarring. The heifers were given Hebrew names that translated to “Comfort,” “Treasure,” “Redemption,” “Hope,” and “Rebirth.” Stinson thought they'd be in Tel Aviv in a matter of days.



Visiting worshippers praying on the ruins at ancient Shiloh.
Photograph by Maya Levin

In the brutal heat of August 2022, workers from a Dallas livestock-transportation company loaded up the chosen heifers at Triple Creek Ranch and took them on a three-day cross-country road trip to New York City. From there, they could fly directly to Tel Aviv in under twelve hours.

But when they reached JFK airport, Stinson hit his biggest obstacle yet: Airline safety regulations restrict the transport of live animals if the temperature at any stop on the itinerary exceeds 85 degrees. Stinson would have to wait until the weather cooled.

Exasperated, he found a facility a few miles from the airport that would house and feed the heifers until fall. Costs were mounting, but he was too far along to turn back now. The bill for shipping the handful of heifers eventually totaled more than \$500,000, about half of which Stinson paid himself; the rest was covered by individual donors and faith-based organizations. On September 15, 2022, the heifers, secured in customized crates, finally landed in Tel Aviv aboard an American Airlines 777.

Stinson was there when the animals touched down at Ben Gurion Airport. So were his wife and son, along with Mamo and rabbis Yisrael Ariel and Azria Ariel, leaders at the Temple Institute. Word about the heifers had spread, and more people started showing up at the airport, forming a crowd that spilled over into the parking lot. There, around fifty people gathered to sing and dance in revelry. A rabbi trumpeted a shofar, a ram's horn used in Jewish rituals. "The Jewish people like to get in a big circle and dance," Stinson told me. "They came and grabbed me, and I danced with them. There was lots of shouting and celebration."

Not everyone in the region was celebrating, though. The arrival of the red heifers was reported in Jewish and Christian media outlets and met with deep concern among Muslim leaders and Palestinian authorities, who have long viewed the campaign to build the Third Temple as a direct threat to their religious heritage and political sovereignty. The introduction of red heifers, or any effort to rebuild the Temple, is seen by many Muslims, Jews, and Christians in the region as a step toward dismantling the fragile principle that has governed Jerusalem's holiest site for nearly sixty years: Worship rights on the Temple Mount belong to Muslims and worship rights at the Western Wall to Jews. "Having a red-heifer ritual means the destruction of the Al-Aqsa Mosque and the building of the Temple instead," said Abdallah Omar, a former spokesperson for the mosque. And any threat

to Al-Aqsa is seen as an attack on Islam. “Making the whole future of our region, which is fragile enough, depend on an idea of a red heifer that’s believed by a minority of religious fanatics—that’s the dangerous part,” Omar said. “The violence might not stop in Palestine or in Jerusalem. It might go all around the world.”

Those concerns soon deepened and gained urgency. In January 2024, on the one hundredth day of the Israel-Hamas war, Abu Obaida, then spokesman for the military wing of Hamas, released a video addressing its October 7, 2023, attack on Israel that left 1,200 people dead and more than 250 people taken hostage. Obaida cited a long list of grievances against Israel, including military aggression, the displacement of Palestinians, and, curiously, the presence of “red cows.”

Around thirty miles from the Temple Mount in the occupied West Bank is ancient Shiloh and some of the Bible’s most sacred sites. There, pilgrims from around the world arrive to visit the heifers from Texas. A new visitors center, funded in part by Boneh Israel, overlooks the two roughly 25-by-75-foot pens the animals live in today. Tourists pay fifteen shekels, or about \$5, to watch an educational video before the screen retracts, revealing the live heifers through a window.

Mamo’s brother manages the site, but the person who helps care for the animals is Larry Borntrager, a 78-year-old retired electrician and ex-dairy farmer from Indiana. Borntrager, a longtime red-heifer enthusiast, assisted the late Texan archaeologist **Vendyl Jones** in 1988 on an unsuccessful dig in the Judean Desert, searching for the ashes of the first red heifer burned in a purification ceremony in the 1400s BC. When Borntrager heard that live red heifers had made it to Israel, he and some friends made a pilgrimage to visit them. He told me he was shocked by what he saw: The sacred animals didn’t have proper bedding and were lying in six-inch-deep manure. Borntrager realized they didn’t have an experienced daily caretaker, so he asked if he could help.

Borntrager received permission from officials in Shiloh to clean up the heifers and improve their living conditions. Borntrager is not Jewish, but he

follows the Seven Laws of Noah, a set of moral laws that, according to Jewish tradition, were given by God to all of humanity after the great flood. He secured new bedding and food for the heifers and soon was so taken by the importance of the task that he decided to stay in Shiloh indefinitely. He's been their caretaker ever since. "I take my job very seriously," he said.

Meanwhile, a consortium of rabbis deliberated on when to hold the ceremony in which a heifer is burned to ashes. To move forward, there must be a majority agreement that laws governing the usage of the red heifer are met. According to Jewish tradition, not even Solomon, the tenth-century BC king whom Jews and Christians recognize as one of the wisest people to have ever lived, fully understood those laws.



Larry Borntrager, the caretaker for the Texan heifers, in ancient Shiloh, in the West Bank, in January 2026.

Photograph by Maya Levin

Stinson said he expected the ceremony to occur during Passover in 2024. Fearing exactly that, Palestinian Christians signed an open letter titled “Promote the Peace of Jerusalem: Stand Against Christian Zionist Extremism,” along with dozens of Christian leaders across the globe. “We

reject in the strongest terms any effort to make Jerusalem into an apocalyptic playground,” the petition read.

Passover came and went, and no ceremony was held. One sticking point: Rabbinical authorities couldn’t agree on whether the heifers were kosher. “This has not been done in two thousand years. There’s no recorded history, as far as I’m aware, of how this process happens,” said Rabbi Joshua Wander, a spokesperson for the Sanhedrin, a modern re-creation of the ancient Jewish high court that once served as Israel’s central governing body for religious and judicial matters. “We’re treading on new ground here. We have to figure it out as we go along.”

According to Wander, Rabbi Azria Ariel, of the Temple Institute, is the world’s foremost authority on the red heifer and perhaps the only figure with the clout to compel the necessary consensus to move forward. Ariel wasn’t satisfied with the candidates. “At this moment, it is unclear whether we have in our possession in Israel a red heifer that is verifiably kosher and suited for the ceremony,” Ariel announced in March 2025. One of the five heifers had sprouted white hairs; another grew warts on the side of its neck.

For Stinson, the announcement stung. He takes umbrage at the rabbis’ concerns; even the ID chips implanted by Davenport are considered by some of them to be blemishes. “Technically, the red heifer can’t carry a burden,” Stinson said. “And technically, this thing that weighs one millionth of an ounce is a burden behind the left ear of the cow—if you want to be super religious about it.”

Wander said Stinson lacks the requisite knowledge of Jewish laws to render any credible judgment. He also attributed Stinson’s impatience to more earthly concerns. “He says he’s leaving it up to the rabbis, but he obviously has ulterior motives,” said Wander, noting that Stinson has put a lot of money, not to mention his own reputation, on the line. “In the end, if it works out, and God wants it to happen, it’ll happen.”

The Temple Institute continued with its other preparations. The group designed architectural plans for the Third Temple and re-created many of

the sacred vessels and garments required for services there. Rabbis from the Temple Institute have even practiced the red-heifer ritual in front of the Al-Aqsa Mosque using a cardboard cutout of a cow. The Temple Institute also runs a school that prepares a priestly class of men who will offer blessings and perform animal sacrifices in the Temple. One such priest has been raised since childhood to perform the red-heifer ceremony, though his identity and the nature of his training have been tightly guarded.

Stinson did eventually grow impatient. He was afraid that the three remaining qualified heifers would soon grow white hairs, so in the summer of 2025, he and Mamo decided to arrange their own practice red-heifer ceremony with Rabbi Ariel and others from the Temple Institute—the better to be prepared for the actual ritual. Borntrager said he warned Stinson and Mamo that even a symbolic ritual would stoke confusion and controversial rumors. But the pair proceeded anyway. They told him they'd use a disqualified heifer, the one who'd developed growths on her neck.

But when Stinson and Mamo went to collect her, Stinson said a different heifer entered the squeeze chute, one that was still considered unblemished. (Borntrager wasn't present that day.) "She basically selected herself," Stinson said Mamo told him. "We're going to just go ahead and use her."

Stinson was shocked—suddenly the ritual had become, to his mind, legitimate. "Now we have a pure priest, pure cow, pure everything," Stinson said.



The heifers on display for visitors at ancient Shiloh.
Photograph by Maya Levin

Stinson had recruited a videographer named Chris Granzow, a Tampa-based real estate investor who runs a Christian Zionist nonprofit, to document the ceremony for an educational video. Granzow declined to send me any footage but agreed to let me view unedited clips on his laptop in person. In November, I met him at one of his properties in Florida. Watching the video, Granzow noted that as the heifer was loaded into the trailer, the other four pressed their bodies against the side of the metal fence, mooing and shifting anxiously in their pen. “It was so sad,” Granzow said. “They definitely knew something was up.”

The heifer was transported for twenty minutes through the rocky hills of Samaria to a private farm about ten miles from ancient Shiloh. Once at the ceremony site, volunteers—Stinson described them as “Israel cowboys”—unloaded her onto a square wooden platform built atop a stack of fig branches, where she was bound using rope. Over the course of about an hour, the ceremony progressed in a plain, workmanlike fashion, guided more by protocol than pageantry. The boyish Jewish priest who’d been raised from birth to conduct this ceremony was flanked by Mamo and Ariel. Two dozen or so others observed.

Just before dusk, the young priest wielded what appeared to be a polished machete and sliced through the heifer's throat. Blood spurted out of the animal and dotted the priest's white linen tunic. The thick, dark liquid resembled maple syrup, slowly pooling on the platform and seeping onto the pyre of fig branches below. The priest reached into the partly decapitated heifer and cupped his hand to fill it with blood. While the bound creature writhed and gurgled at his feet, the priest sprinkled the blood seven times in the direction of the Temple Mount. Then, using what appeared to be lighter fluid, he set the red heifer on fire.

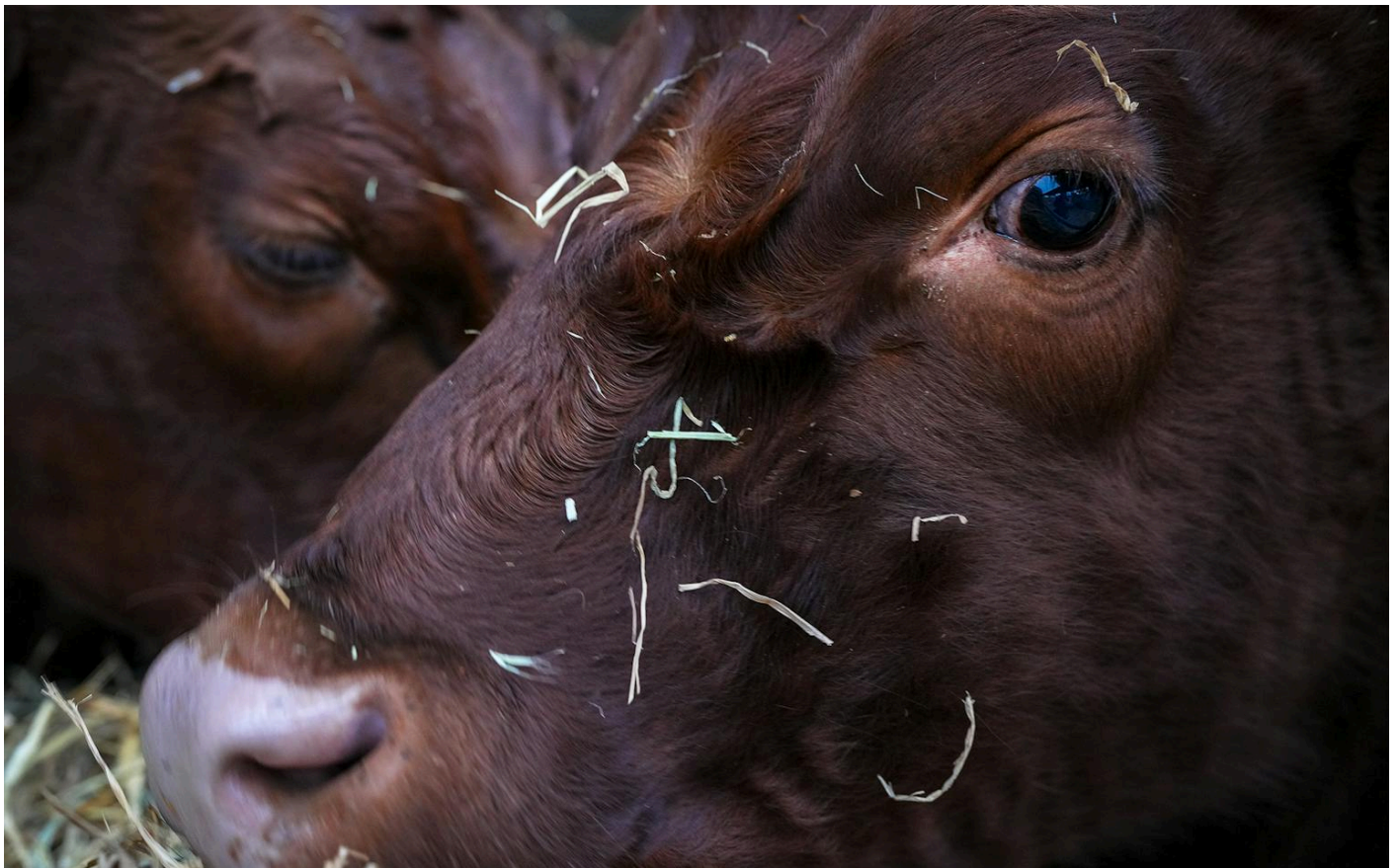
As the pyre caught and flames engulfed the heifer, Mamo danced and sang with his fellow Jewish onlookers. Stinson observed from a distance; he hadn't disclosed the last-minute switch to Ariel and didn't know if Mamo had. Watching Mamo and others celebrate, he felt like a football player cheering his team from the sidelines. He watched in awe, believing he had just witnessed the first red-heifer ceremony performed in two thousand years. "It was incredible to be allowed to see the word of God come to life," he told me.

The heifer burned for twelve hours, and it took several days for the ashes to cool. Once collected, the ashes filled three five-gallon buckets—enough, Stinson says, to purify every person on earth. (Only a speck of the ashes is needed to create the water mixture required to cleanse ritual impurity, so a pinch of ash can theoretically purify thousands of people.)

A week later, unauthorized video of the ceremony shot by one of the onlookers leaked to a conservative Israeli news outlet. Just as Borntrager had warned, controversy over its legitimacy swirled. To quell concerns, the Temple Institute stated on Facebook that the ceremony had been an exercise. Shortly after, the Sanhedrin released its own statement supporting the Temple Institute's position. According to the Temple Institute, the ceremony wasn't kosher because it didn't take place on the Mount of Olives, and the heifer had a disqualifying defect. "Anyone who claims otherwise," the statement read, "is mistaken and misleading, either intentionally or unintentionally."

Borntrager agreed. Though he wasn't present during the ceremony, he said that when he returned to ancient Shiloh in early August, the heifer with the warts on its side wasn't there anymore. "Byron knows it wasn't a perfect cow," Borntrager told me.

Stinson, though, was adamant that the ceremony was real—that the heifer they burned was unblemished and the ashes they produced are kosher. He claimed to have proof: The ashes, he says, have healing properties. He gave some to his wife and said using them, along with medical care, helped clear up memory issues that have plagued her since she was injured in a car accident four decades ago. It's a puzzling claim, not least because scripture doesn't ascribe healing properties to ashes produced by a red-heifer ceremony. It's also not something Temple Institute rabbis have ever asserted, nor is it part of any criteria they use to determine a ritual's authenticity.



Up close with the red heifers from Texas at ancient Shiloh.
Photograph by Maya Levin

In early January, I called Stinson to press him on the matter. We'd been in touch off and on in the period leading up to the ceremony and after it. I wanted to ask him again how it could have been kosher when it didn't happen on the Mount of Olives, when the status of the heifer was in question, and when all the religious authorities who regulate the ceremony declared that it was merely an exercise.

What's more, at least two qualified red heifers remain at ancient Shiloh, and Stinson told me he plans to live stream the ceremony if and when another occurs. Why, if he believed the initial ceremony had worked, would he want to do it all over again?

By then, I'd spoken with Stinson around a dozen times over the previous two years, often for multiple hours. The riff he delivered that day in January was typical, blending esoteric Christian doctrine with complicated Jewish theology in ways that Jewish scholars I've consulted tell me are completely nonsensical. "God orchestrates these things in ways that we don't expect," Stinson told me. "I don't know where it's going exactly, but we have the ashes, and they work, and they have power in them."

A small jar of those ashes happened to be sitting on my desk. Granzow had given them to me when I visited him in Tampa. I asked Stinson what I should do with them.

It's simple, he told me. Mix the ashes with spring water (he suggested the Texas brand Ozarka), sprinkle myself with the solution, and then repent. "You don't have to tell any of your neighbors," he said. "Some of them are going to think you're crazy."

Andrew Logan is a writer and producer based in Austin. He has produced feature films and documentaries that have premiered at the Sundance Film Festival, South by Southwest, and TIFF.

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